

THE ROCKY ROAD TO DUBLIN, mid-1800s, D.K. Gavan

Intro: Am G Am; ; Bass strum; minor changes by Lew Toulmin 2024-5

[Am] In the merry month of June, from me home I started, left the girls of Tuam,
[G] so sad and broken hearted, [Am] saluted Father dear, kissed me darling mother
Drank a pint of beer, [G] me grief and tears to smother
[Am] Then off to reap the [G] corn, [Am] leave where I was [G] born
[Am] Cut a stout [G] blackthorn, to banish ghosts and goblins
[Am] Bought a pair of [G] brogues, [Am] rattlin' o'er the [G] bogs
[Am] Frightenin' all the [G] dogs, on the rocky road to Dublin

CHORUS: [Am] One two [G] three four [Am] five
Hunt the Hare and turn her, down the rocky road
And [G] all the way to Dublin, [Am] whack for [G] al de [Am] rah!

[Am] In Mullingar that night, I rested limbs so weary, started by daylight,
[G] me spirits bright and airy, [Am] Took a drop o' the pure, to keep me heart from sinking
That's the Paddy's cure, [G] whenever he's on for drinking
[Am] And I saw the lassies [G] smile, [Am] laughing all the [G] while
[Am] At me curious [G] style, 'twould set your heart a bubblin'
[Am] They asked if I was [G] hired, [Am] wages I [G] required?
[Am] 'Till I was nearly [G], tired! On the rocky road to Dublin **CHORUS**

[Am] In Dublin next arrived, I thought it such a pity, to be so soon deprived,
[G] a view of that fine city, [Am] well then I took a stroll, all among the quality
Bundle it was stole, [G] all in a neat locality
[Am] Somethin' crossed me [G] mind, [Am] when I looked [G] behind
[Am] No bundle could I [G] find, upon me stick a wobblin'
[Am] Enquiring for the [G] rogue, [Am] they said me Connaught [G] brogue
[Am] Wasn't much in [G] vogue, on the rocky road to Dublin **CHORUS**

[Am] From there I got away, me spirits never failing, landed on the quay,
[G] Just as the ship was sailin', [Am] the Captain at me roared, said that no room had he
But when I jumped aboard, [G] a cabin found for Paddy
[Am] Down among the [G] pigs! [Am] So I played some funny [G] rigs
[Am] Danced some hearty [G] jigs, the water round me bubbling
[Am] But when off Holy [G] head, [Am] wished meself was [G] dead
[Am] Or better far in [G] stead -- on the rocky road to Dublin! **CHORUS**

[Am] Well, the boys of Liverpool, when we safely landed, called meself a fool,
[G] I could no longer stand it, [Am] me blood began to boil, temper I was losing
Poor old Erin's isle, [G] they began abusing
[Am] "Hurrah me soul!" [G] says I, [Am] shillelagh I let [G] fly
[Am] Some Galway boys were [G] nigh, and saw I was a hobblin'
[Am] With a loud [G] "Hurray!" -- [Am] they joined me in the [G] affray
[Am] We quickly cleared the [G] way, on that rocky road from Dublin

CHORUS: [Am] One two [G] three four [Am] five
Hunt the Hare and turn her, down the rocky road
And [G] all the way to Dublin, [Am] whack fo [G] ral de [Am] rah!

[Am] whack fo [G] ral de [Am] rah!

[Single]: [Am] Whack fo [G] ral de [Am] rah!

“Reap the corn” means to make some money, similar to “earn a crust of bread.” Our hero is headed from the west coast of Ireland across Ireland to Liverpool to find work, like many other Irishmen who sought work in England.

“Hunt the Hare” is an Irish jig, so he wants you to dance and “turn” your partner all the way to Dublin

“Funny rigs” are fun musical compositions

Our hero’s “bundle” was “wobblin’” at the end of his “blackthorn” walking stick/weapon/shillelagh and was stolen in a nice neighborhood. The locals didn’t want to help him find the bad guy, because of his west country accent.

Off Holyhead (the Welsh port on the NW coast of the island of Anglesey, on the Irish Sea), where our hero was on his way to Liverpool, he got seasick, and hence “wished meself was dead,” as did many other passengers on that route, and really wanted to be back on land, in Ireland, “on the rocky road to Dublin”!